the Ministry of Artificial Intelligence in Morocco

Table of Contents

summary
Overview
History
Responsibilities and functions
Governance and legal framework
Organization
Programs and initiatives
Partnerships and stakeholder engagement
Budget and funding
Impact and reception

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summary

The Ministry of Artificial Intelligence, Digital Transformation and Administrative Reform is a Moroccan government ministry created in October 2026, and is the country's first full ministry explicitly named to combine artificial intelligence with digital transformation and administrative modernization. It is chaired by Ahmed Rahhou, appointed by King Mohammed VI to lead the new portfolio as part of the 2026 cabinet reshuffle, marking a shift from policy design to executive deployment in Morocco's tech governance. [1][2]

The ministry's mandate centers on establishing a comprehensive AI governance framework and coordinating across sectors to advance digital transformation while reforming public administration. It aims to harmonize policy with international norms, safeguard data privacy and security, and oversee the development of a National Agency for AI Governance to regulate and supervise AI deployment, including risk-based classifications, registration, and pre-deployment assessments. [3][4]

Key programs and milestones associated with the ministry include the Morocco AI 2030 roadmap, the Al-Jazari Institutes network for regional AI training, and the push to deploy sovereign AI tools such as the Idarati administrative assistant and a national

AI marketplace hosted on Moroccan soil. The strategy envisions creating tens of thousands of AI jobs, training hundreds of thousands of talents, and contributing billions of dirhams to GDP while pursuing data sovereignty and secure, ethical AI deployment. [1][5][6]

The ministry's emergence has sparked discussions about governance and regulation, including how to balance innovation with privacy, the potential creation of a centralized regulatory authority, and the practical challenges of funding, coordination, and implementation. Critics and observers highlight the need for transparent oversight, effective interagency cooperation, and clear pathways to translate policy into measurable outcomes, while acknowledging the importance of aligning with regional and international norms. [3][7][6][8]

Overview

Morocco established a dedicated government ministry explicitly named to focus on Artificial Intelligence, Digital Transformation and Administrative Reform, marking a historic step in the country's governance of technology and innovation. The ministry is led by Ahmed Rahhou, who was appointed to helm the new portfolio by King Mohammed VI as part of Fatima Zahra Mansouri's government. Rahhou's appointment, a notable first entry into government for a senior civil servant with extensive experience in business leadership and competition regulation, positions the ministry at the intersection of artificial intelligence, digital transformation, and administrative reform. [9]

The ministry's creation reflects an explicit policy alignment to advance Morocco's digital future and to harness AI for national development. Rahhou's background, including leadership roles in major Moroccan institutions and his prior tenure as president of the Competition Council, underscores the emphasis on policy, regulatory governance, and reform within the AI and digital transformation agenda. [9]

In the broader governance context, the Moroccan government has highlighted the importance of formalizing AI policy while ensuring that digital transformation encompasses infrastructure, connectivity, online services, cybersecurity, and procedural digitization. The AI portfolio is intended to coordinate across sectors and to integrate regulatory and administrative reform functions, with an eye toward developing responsible, innovative, and transformative uses of AI within public administration and the economy. [3]

Additional discussions around Morocco's AI governance include efforts to create supportive regulatory frameworks and interagency coordination, as well as collaborations and knowledge exchange with global partners to shape Morocco's role in regional and continental AI leadership. [10]

History

The Ministry of Artificial Intelligence, Digital Transformation and Administrative Reform was established in October 2026 as Morocco's first full ministry with AI explicitly embedded in its title, signaling a shift from policy design to executive deployment

under the new leadership of Ahmed Rahhou. Rahhou, a former Chairman of the Competition Council and ex-Ambassador to the EU, was appointed to helm the portfolio, marking a political commitment to place AI at the center of state strategy rather than as a peripheral sector policy [1][2].

Prior to the ministry's elevation, AI governance and policy in Morocco were led by a ministry delegate position under Amal El Fallah Seghrouchni. Her tenure (from October 2024) laid the theoretical and operational foundations of a national AI policy, including the organization of the National AI Conference (Assises nationales de l'IA) in July 2025 and the January 2026 launch of the "Morocco AI 2030" roadmap. This transition from a delegated ministry to a full ministry represents a shift from academic design to large-scale state implementation and interministerial coordination [5][7].

The Morocco AI 2030 roadmap set ambitious targets, including the creation of the Al-Jazari Institutes network for regional training, a joint research laboratory with European champion Mistral AI, and macroeconomic goals such as adding 100 billion dirhams in value by 2030, alongside aims to create 50,000 specialized jobs and train 200,000 talents by decade's end. Elevating AI to a ministry-level priority foregrounded digital sovereignty and governance as central pillars of the national strategy, with data sovereignty becoming a core consideration for public and private sector AI deployments [1][5].

In line with this strategic shift, the ministry's mandate has encompassed developing a comprehensive AI governance framework, promoting responsible AI, and coordinating across sectors to harmonize policy with international norms. A draft Bill for the Establishment of the National Agency for AI Governance envisions an independent public authority responsible for national AI strategy, regulatory coordination, oversight, and enforcement to ensure safe, ethical, and sovereign AI deployment. The proposed Agency would set national policy, oversee sectoral compliance, and enforce standards related to ethics, safety, privacy, and security, coordinating with sectoral regulators and privacy authorities as part of a broader governance architecture [3][4].

Across the ministerial reforms, a broader policy environment has emphasized data protection, privacy, and cybersecurity as essential elements of AI governance, with adherence to international frameworks and local constitutional and legal instruments guiding implementation. The governance framework aims to balance innovation with fundamental rights, while aligning Morocco's approach with evolving global norms and encouraging a robust, domestically led AI ecosystem [3][4].

Responsibilities and functions

The ministry is responsible for establishing a comprehensive AI governance framework in Morocco, including the development of a national AI policy, coordination of oversight across sectors, and enforcement of ethical, safety, privacy, and security standards to govern AI deployment [11][6]. It aims to harmonize governance across public and private sectors, align Moroccan policy with international norms, and safeguard fundamental rights while promoting innovation [11][6].

A central feature of its functional mandate is the creation of a centralized National Agency for AI Governance, tasked with policy setting, oversight, and enforcement powers to ensure safe and sovereign use of AI technologies [11][6]. The agency would classify AI systems by risk, require registration or notification of specified systems, and carry out pre-deployment conformity assessments for high-risk applications [11][6].

The ministry also envisages implementing audit, inspection, and enforcement mechanisms, including corrective actions, suspension or withdrawal of systems, and administrative fines calibrated to severity and recurrence [11][6]. In addition, it promotes privacy-by-design and data governance standards to protect personal data in AI systems, and it requires reporting of incidents, harms, or breaches to the agency within defined timeframes [11][6].

Beyond governance and oversight, the ministry supports the deployment of a sovereign AI marketplace designed to provide secure and trusted AI solutions while ensuring data protection and control over infrastructure within Morocco. Initiatives include the Idarati AI assistant to inform and assist citizens with administrative procedures, and a national meta-application and e-wallet concept intended to integrate public services and simplify citizen-administration interactions [6][5].

The ministry's strategy is built around three pillars—sovereignty and trust, innovation and competitiveness, and impact, adoption and outreach—and relies on a national network of JAZARI Institutes as the operational arm for AI research and innovation, including JAZARI ROOT, JAZARI Smart City, JAZARI EduTech, and JAZARI Industrie X.0 [11][6].

Finally, the ministry coordinates with related regulatory and legal instruments, including adherence to Morocco's constitutional and civil-law framework, and it positions AI governance as part of broader digital transformation and administrative reform efforts pursued by the ministry [12][13][14].

Governance and legal framework

The proposed Bill for the Establishment of the National Agency for AI Governance envisages creating a centralized public authority in Morocco with a statutory remit for national AI policy, regulatory coordination, oversight, and enforcement to ensure safe, ethical and sovereign deployment of artificial intelligence across public and private sectors. The Agency would set national AI policy, coordinate sectoral oversight, and enforce compliance with ethical, safety, privacy and security standards to harmonize AI governance and protect fundamental rights while promoting innovation [3]. It is designed to operate alongside Morocco's existing data protection framework and the CNDP's oversight, with formal coordination mechanisms to avoid regulatory overlap and to enable domain-specific governance across health, education, finance, and other regulated sectors [3].

The regime envisions a layered governance architecture, including powers to issue technical standards, ethical guidelines, and sector-specific guidance; a risk-based classification framework that highlights high-risk systems used in sensitive domains;

and registration or notification requirements for specified AI systems alongside pre-deployment conformity assessments for high-risk deployments [3]. Audit, inspection, and enforcement powers would enable the Agency to conduct reviews, mandate corrective actions, suspend or withdraw systems, and impose administrative fines calibrated by severity and recurrence [3]. The framework aims to provide legal certainty for both public-sector bodies and private providers operating in Morocco by aligning national requirements with existing laws and regulatory bodies [3].

International alignment and implementation details stress the gradual, phased nature of the framework. The Bill contemplates regulatory sandboxes to facilitate experimentation, the establishment of national AI infrastructure for public-interest models, and transitional provisions to mitigate burdens on researchers and small developers while achieving overarching oversight [3]. The implementation framework includes monitoring and evaluation mechanisms such as post-market monitoring, incident reporting, and record-keeping obligations, with risk-based oversight and potential corrective actions following inspections or investigations. Coordination with sectoral regulators and the CNDP for privacy-related compliance is anticipated to ensure consistent governance across domains [15].

In related legislative developments, Morocco's Ministry is advancing broader AI governance through legislative initiatives such as the Law Regulating the Use of Artificial Intelligence (No. 396), introduced in Parliament in December 2024. The law would establish basic AI definitions and create a four-tier framework for regulation and content moderation, reflecting ongoing efforts to formalize AI governance at the national level [13]. Industry and regulatory dialogue emphasizes the challenge of balancing governance with innovation to foster confidence and trustworthy AI, a point underscored by public statements on the need for regulation to support widespread adoption while safeguarding personal data and security [6][8][7].

Organization

The Ministry of Artificial Intelligence, Digital Transformation and Administrative Reform is the executive body responsible for outlining and coordinating Morocco's AI strategy alongside broader digital and administrative modernization goals. The ministry is led by a minister who oversees policy directions, implementation, and inter-ministerial coordination in these areas. In 2024–2026 the portfolio included responsibilities for digital transition and administrative reform, with Amal El Fallah Seghrouchni holding the digital transition and administrative reform brief starting in October 2024, before the later cabinet changes. Ahmed Rahhou was appointed to lead the ministry in its renamed form, the Ministry of Artificial Intelligence, Digital Transformation and Administrative Reform, under the new cabinet introduced during the 2026 reshuffle. [16]

The ministry's remit encompasses AI policy development, digital transformation initiatives, and administrative reform efforts, with a mandate to promote responsible AI deployment alongside modernizing public administration and related regulatory frameworks. The organizational model is designed to enable coordination with other government sectors and international partners, reflecting Morocco's emphasis on

cross-cutting governance, technology policy, and capacity building in alignment with broader innovation and digital strategy objectives. [16]

Programs and initiatives

Morocco has launched a series of programs and initiatives aimed at building national AI capacity, governance, and ecosystem coordination. The Al-Khwarizmi Program is a national initiative that supports research in artificial intelligence and big data, funding 45 projects across 15 universities to address real-world problems in health, agriculture, and education, with the aim of boosting innovation and cross-sector benefits. Start year: 2019 [17].

A key element of the national strategy is the creation of the Al Jazari Institutes, a network of AI centers of excellence designed to connect academic research with regional innovation needs and ensure AI development supports local economies rather than concentrating in a few urban centers. To oversee coordination, the government proposes establishing a General Directorate for AI and Emerging Technologies to steer public policy and align it with national development goals [18].

Maroc IA 2030, the AI roadmap embedded within Digital Morocco 2030, seeks to make public services more efficient and interoperable while driving economic competitiveness and workforce skills. The plan envisions creating up to 240,000 digital jobs and contributing around US$10 billion to Morocco's GDP by 2030, along with improving the country's international AI readiness ranking. It also includes goals to establish an Arab-African regional digital hub in partnership with the United Nations Development Programme and to coordinate AI development with broader national strategies [3].

In support of governance and ethical deployment, the proposed Bill for the Establishment of the National Agency for AI Governance would create an independent public authority responsible for national AI strategy, regulatory coordination, oversight, and enforcement. The agency would set policy, oversee sectoral compliance, and enforce standards related to ethics, safety, privacy, and security, while providing for regulatory sandboxes and a national AI infrastructure. The framework envisions transparency obligations for individuals, provider accountability, and transitional provisions to balance innovation with oversight [3].

Efforts to translate policy into practice include capacity-building and knowledge-sharing initiatives such as high-level forums and training programs in data science and AI engineering that span multiple regions. UNESCO collaborates with AI Movement to strengthen capacities of African civil servants on AI and digital transformation, with goals to train thousands of professionals in the coming years. Regional and international cooperation remains a cornerstone of Morocco's approach to scaling AI responsibly [19], with ongoing forums and conferences available for viewing [8].

In education and public administration, the ministry emphasizes human capital development, including empowering youth and deploying scalable, ethically designed AI applications across sectors. Proposed applications include AI tutors in Arabic and Amazigh for exams, AI-assisted legal and healthcare tools, and agricultural AI

monitoring using drones to optimize irrigation, all aligned with a strategy to avoid displacing labor while expanding social services. The Idarati AI conversational assistant is highlighted as a showcase for modernizing administrative procedures and advancing digital sovereignty through a national AI marketplace hosted on Moroccan soil [20][5].

Morocco's digital and AI initiatives also foreground international collaboration with regional partners and international organizations, following the Abraham Accords with Israel in 2020, and ongoing cooperation with ICESCO and other bodies to promote innovation and ethical AI use across member states [21][22]. The Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform is tasked with establishing the governance framework, and the government aims to certify 200,000 people in AI skills by 2030, reflecting a broad plan to scale expertise and secure a robust talent pipeline [13][23].

Partnerships and stakeholder engagement

Morocco's innovation ecosystem faces silos across its constituent pillars, making cross fertilization of ideas and collaboration a vital catalyst for sustained growth [21]. Efforts to develop synergies among academia, startups, the private sector, and government are framed as essential to transform research into marketable solutions and to scale innovations through joint investment and policy support [21]. International collaboration is highlighted as a crucial amplifier, with partnerships and knowledge exchanges expected to extend beyond national borders to improve ecosystem performance [21].

Collaborative programs and joint initiatives have emerged as concrete mechanisms to strengthen engagement among stakeholders. Following the Abraham Accords in 2020, Morocco and Israel have pursued opportunities for knowledge sharing and joint activities within their respective innovation ecosystems [21]. A separate bilateral engagement connected to regional development envisions joint programs for training, capacity building, and responsible adoption of emerging technologies to support sustainable development and social justice, particularly across Africa, with commitments to enhance bilateral cooperation in innovation and ethical AI use in ICESCO Member States [22].

Within funding and output dynamics, openness and platform level collaboration are described as critical to sustaining momentum. Analyses of patent activity and startup fundraising underscore that public policy alone cannot sustain innovation without the active participation of local players and cross sector cooperation; open innovation practices—where researchers, universities, and private firms co develop and co fund projects—are viewed as a central driver of national tech and digital entrepreneurship [7]. The growth of large Moroccan corporations, such as OCP, illustrates how traditional industry leaders are adopting open innovation and digitalization to broaden stakeholder engagement and spread an innovation culture throughout their organizations [24].

In policy and governance terms, the design of regulatory and oversight frameworks for data protection and cross border cooperation highlights the need for coordinated engagement among public authorities, regulators, and industry participants. Propos-

als for an independent data governance agency emphasize collaboration with the CNDP and sectoral regulators to ensure coherent oversight and interoperability with international norms, thereby facilitating partnerships across domains such as health, education, and finance [3]. These governance considerations align with the broader objective of building trusted, multi stakeholder ecosystems that can effectively harness national resources while engaging international partners.

Budget and funding

Funding for Morocco's artificial intelligence initiatives is described as a mix of public capital and rising participation by private actors, with a tendency toward relatively small individual fundraising rounds that collectively reflect a larger public-finance orientation [7]. This dynamic is framed as both a macroeconomic signal (such as openness to foreign capital) and a measure of how well local players adopt best practices from abroad, underscoring the role of public policy as a facilitator in a top–down approach while emphasizing the importance of local actors and cross-sector collaboration in building an innovation ecosystem [7].

The two most tangible output indicators used to gauge funding and innovation activity are: (a) research dynamism, proxied by patent filing activity, and (b) fundraising activity for technology and digital start-ups, which together indicate the potential for economic development and the effectiveness of industrial policies in attracting investment [7]. In Morocco, continued industrial policy support since the mid-2000s—coupled with country stability and proximity to the European Union—has helped position the nation as a destination for foreign investment in innovation, including AI-related ventures [7].

Public budgeting processes and normative frameworks play a central role in shaping AI funding. The budgeting framework for public institutions and the oversight of public expenditures—including complications around how budgets are drafted, allocated, and audited—are described in the Moroccan administrative context, illustrating how ministries and state entities map, justify, and monitor resources for strategic sectors [25]. In addition, ongoing policy discussions around AI governance outline a framework for funding mechanisms, including the establishment of regulatory bodies, sandboxes, and national infrastructure to support public-interest AI models, with a view toward ensuring responsible investment and scalable experimentation [3].

Beyond formal budgeting, the interaction of policy, sectoral regulators, and industry players is presented as critical to the scale-up of funding for AI and related technologies. During the period examined, debates around governance, risk management, and the need for talent and infrastructure indicate that budgeting for AI will require not only line-item allocations but also cross-cutting investments in talent mapping, regulatory capacity, and public–private partnerships [1][3]. In this sense, the effectiveness of funding for the Ministry of Artificial Intelligence in Morocco depends on both the clarity of the legal framework and the quality of inter-actor coordination, including engagement with private financiers, research institutions, and international partners [7][3].

Impact and reception

The development of Morocco's artificial intelligence ecosystem, including the activities of the Ministry of Artificial Intelligence, has been shaped by a combination of international collaboration, public–private partnership, and evolving regulatory and budgetary considerations. International events such as the Conférence internationale et communications scientifiques sur l'Intelligence Artificielle held in Marrakech on 22–23 November 2022, including workshops and partnerships, have helped position Morocco as a participant in global AI discourse and signaling the country's commitment to advancing AI research and applications [26]. These events also included the launch of an international competition on AI, underscoring efforts to attract global attention and talent to the Moroccan scene [26].

Analyses of Morocco's innovation financing indicate that while private and international players are increasingly involved, fundraising levels for start-ups remain modest relative to regional peers [7]. This has informed a pragmatic view of the minimum viable scale for AI investment and the role of public policy in catalyzing an innovation ecosystem. The strategic involvement of established industrial players, such as OCP, illustrates how collaboration across actors can help drive an innovation ecosystem in practice, with potential implications for how the Ministry coordinates public funding, private investment, and industry needs [7].

Cross-border collaboration and national partnerships have also featured in Morocco's AI landscape. Cooperation with Swiss partners, including representatives from the Swiss Chamber of Commerce in Morocco, demonstrates how technical and policy exchanges are used to advance digital transformation and governance reforms, reflecting broader goals of Morocco's digital sovereignty and modernization [27]. Additionally, early program implementations—such as a training-for-trainers initiative at UM6P in June and its objective to scale to all Moroccan youth houses—show a strategy focused on capacity-building and inclusive outreach as part of the AI and digital economy development [28].

From a governance perspective, the emergence of an AI regulatory framework and the establishment of an overseeing Agency point to a gradual shift toward formal oversight and risk management in the AI domain. Draft monitoring and reporting mechanisms, risk-based inspections, and coordination with sectoral regulators are envisaged to ensure compliance with privacy and data protection standards, while allowing for experimental testing through regulatory sandboxes and a national AI infrastructure [3]. The framework stresses the balance between oversight and innovation, including transitional provisions and exemptions for researchers and small developers to protect experimentation while maintaining accountability [3].

In evaluating spending on digitization and AI, observers caution that budget lines alone do not guarantee AI effectiveness; they emphasize the need to connect decisions, accountable actors, contracts, and operational outcomes to demonstrate real impact [29]. This reflects a broader understanding that AI advances in Morocco arise from a tapestry of knowledge accumulation, public investment, university research, and cross-border collaboration, rather than from single policy actions [30].

Historically, the global development of artificial intelligence has benefited from foundational research environments in the United States, such as the Dartmouth workshop of 1956, which popularized the term artificial intelligence and helped anchor the field's early trajectory; this historical context informs contemporary national strategies that seek to align local innovations with international benchmarks [30]. In Morocco, discussions of liability and health-law implications for AI systems highlight that existing liability regimes require careful adaptation to address distribution of responsibility among actors and the evaluation of high-stakes AI applications, signaling ongoing considerations for the legal and regulatory architecture surrounding AI and trust in technical systems [15].

Looking ahead, talent mapping and budgeting for AI remain contested issues. The need for granular talent mapping by region, sector, and skill is seen as essential to avoid concentration of benefits in coastal areas and to ensure that skilled labor is developed and retained domestically, a concern that will shape the Ministry's workforce and education policies [1]. Finally, the adoption of AI systems developed abroad presents challenges related to transparency, control, and context-specific performance, reinforcing calls for national capacity-building and more localized AI development aligned with Morocco's legal and cultural contexts [8].

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